THE SINO-INDIAN WAR, 1962

Although India was among the first countries to grant diplomatic recognition to the People's Republic of China, the Chinese annexation of Tibet in 1951 changed the situation, with Chinese maps claiming territory south of the McMahon Line (agreed as part of the 1914 Simla Convention) and periodic Chinese cross-border incursions. In 1960, India adopted the 'Forward Policy', prompting China to strengthen its military positions in Tibet. China set up several new military posts in the Ladakh region and by early 1962 was conducting aggressive military actions along the border. In July 1962 Chinese forces surrounded an Indian position in the Galwan Valley in Ladakh, followed by a clash between the two sides at Lake Pangong.

On 8 September 1962, approximately 600 Chinese troops occupied Thagla Ridge in the eastern sector that was well inside the McMahon Line. In response, 7 Infantry Brigade (4 Infantry Division) occupied defences below the Thagla Ridge along the Namka Chu (Kejielang River) and launched Operation *Leghorn* to evict the Chinese. A force of approximately 50–60 troops from 9 PUNJAB attempted to outflank Chinese positions, but the Indians were beaten back after an intense firefight with over 1,000 Chinese troops.

On 20 October all positions of 7 Infantry Brigade were subjected to a relentless Chinese artillery barrage followed by an infantry assault. By 22 October, Chinese forces had advanced along two axes from the Namka Chu area towards Tawang with one division leading and another in reserve. On a third axis, from Bum La, the Chinese were held for more than eight hours by a platoon of 1 SIKH, losing over 300 troops before they overwhelmed the Indian defenders. The Chinese faced similar opposition in the Walong sector near the tri-junction of India, Bhutan and China. Troops of 6 KUMAON and 4 SIKH inflicted heavy casualties on the Chinese, but were compelled to withdraw.